

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Life from Death ~ Salvation in the Here and Now
Eastertide 3

May 11th, 2025



Umbria vergine, 1949 - Gerardo Dottori

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Improvisation on LAND OF REST and REGENT'S SQUARE

Two Chant Meditations: Ave Maria, Ave Verum Corpus (Kevin Waters)

Three Marian Chants (Improvisations)

- Salve Regina
- Ave Maris Stella
- Regina Caeli

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman & Claire Kelly

Words of Gathering

Members of First Church Youth

In a world of differences
we are challenged to see the sacred
in many faces and many traditions.

In this world of options,
we are challenged to remain true to what we know
of that sacredness, of ourselves, of those we love.

In this world of blessing,
we know gifts of beauty and wonder
and seek to ground them in all holiness.

May the differences we find this day
bless us with a deep and sustained
awareness of the Presence of the Sacred
in our oft-confusing world.

*We ask this as those who, given a choice,
choose life!*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

The Universe in God

REGENT SQUARE

All creation sings a story
Of great splendours to declare;
When we contemplate its beauty
We are called forth into prayer.
We, enchanted, stand in silence;
God discovered everywhere.

When we stumble on new knowledge,
When new insights help us grow,
We are quick to re-discover
Just how much we do not know.
But the Universe smiles gently,
As our theories come and go.

Ageless mystery still excite us;
Time and space we must explore.
God the 'Presence' and 'Surrounding,'
God the ever wondrous 'More' -
Not just found by science labours,
But in praise when we adore.

-lyrics by George Stuart

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Through your presence, O God,
we recognize the choices we make
craft us into who we are becoming.
Whether for good or ill,
it is what comes from within
that tells of who we are.

From the beginning creation was called *very good*.
On this day, may we sense the immense import
of that reality,
and find, deep within ourselves,
the power to create,
to birth ourselves into being.

May we remember that we are light,
and on this day, choose to live beauty and love in the world.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"Hanacpachap Cussicuinin"
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, Assistant Director

ANONYMOUS QUECHUAN HYMN
FROM PERU

*"The bliss of heaven! I bring gratitude to you a thousandfold. O hope of humankind,
long awaited by your people. Protection of spiritual strength: heed my call."*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Claire Kelly

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people.
This day, tonight, and forever.
Amen and Amen!*

[John Philip Newell]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Emily Kang & Rev. Lehman

Peace for the earth and its creatures
peace for the world and its peoples
peace for those who become our mothers
peace for those who become our fathers
peace for those who become our siblings.

The peace of heaven's vastness
the peace of the ocean's depths
the peace of earth's stillness
to bless us this day
to bless us this day.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

Gavin Gregorio & Claire Kelly

from the Book of Romans and the Gospel of Luke

These are the words of hope.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayers of Our Hearts

O God, as we seek powers that save, this day,
in the face of suffering and difficulty,
help us to experience your surrounding presence,

When we see others in need,
*open our eyes and ears
that we may see this need
and move to help
in whatever way we can
with sacred wisdom, to tend to one another's needs.*

When thinking of others,
we hold in our hearts
millions of people all over the world
who are in these times, seeking to be saved.
We pray for those facing war
in their home, on the streets, in their minds.
We pray for those facing disasters,
of ruin from storms of life,
*On this day, we pray that we might act
where and when we can
to serve, do justice,
and work with you as partners
to save our world.*

May it be so.
*May it be so for all of us,
both now, and in all the days to come.
Amen and Amen!*

Meditation Anthem

"Bogoroditse Devo"
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, Assistant Director

SERGEI RACHMANINOFF

*Rejoice, O Virgin, Mary full of grace, the Lord is with Thee. Blessed art
Thou among women, for Thou hast borne the Savior of our souls.*

Sermon

Salvation in the Here and Now

Rev. Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

*Blessed are you, O God,
Who brings forth the bread of partnership
From the earth.*

This sustains us:
The daily sharing
the companioned seeking
the mutual blessing
the tender feeding.

Partnered with one another
and with you, O God,
we partake of Mystery.
*When the way is dangerous,
when our angers rise,
this tastes most sweet.*

Bless to us
this companion-created loaf,
that its toughness may yield
your flavor-full joy.

Bless to us
this cup that comes from many parts
pressed into one
that we might taste its sweetness.

[jrichardson/adptlvf]

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity & Words of Response

Rev. Lehman

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"Ihr habt nun Traurigkeit" Ein Deutsches Requiem Movement 5

JOHANNES BRAHMS

Tiffany Ho, Soprano, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Orchestral Reduction*, Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

Ye now are sorrowful, howbeit ye shall again behold me, and your heart shall be joyful, and your joy no man taketh from you. Yea, I will comfort you, as one whom his own mother comforteth. Look upon me; ye know that for a little time labor and sorrow were mine, but at the last I have found comfort.

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Rev. Lehman

Gracious and Loving God,
may the bread and the offerings we have shared this day,
be food for the journey as we seek to see the new reality
of your kin-dom in the world.

In the same way, may the cup we have shared,
be a reminder that we are no longer tied to the old order.
May the memory of this table shared, be a place where our hopes are forged.

May this community gathered here be a reminder
that we are not alone-
There are others seeking the way of Jesus
as we work together to bring peace and justice
each and every day of our lives.

And every time we share this meal and give our offerings
of time, of talent, of goodness and of grace,
may we be reminded of the gifts we share
that comes to us from the life, death,
and life from death of Jesus the Christ.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

May the God of the heavens
and of the earth
enter into the places
within us
that hold the keenest chaos,
the deepest mystery,
the most intense and beautiful darkness...

And there,
may the God of
Sun and Moon
Stars and Seasons
breathe the words
that will bring forth
a new world.

-Jan Richardson

Choral Response

"Let There Be Peace On Earth"

SY MILLER & JILL JACKSON, arr.

Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organ* MARY MCDONALD

***Hymn for the Journey**

We Come With Joy

LAND OF REST

We came with seekers far and near
To find as all are fed,
The new community of love
In Christ's communion bread

As Christ breaks bread and bids us share
Each proud division ends.
The love that made us
Makes us one,
And strangers now are friends

And thus we meet and better know
The Presence ever near
And join our hearts and sing with joy
Of love that brings us here.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on *Regina Caeli* (C. Bull)

Inside The Music

"Today we sing music that celebrates the Divine Feminine and Mary as an icon of the feminist movement: the concerns for global peace, dismantling patriarchal power, living of and with the Earth, and liberating people from the holds of traditional gender roles all find deep resonance in Marian Feminism and Devotion. Mary somehow knew the child she conceived was coming to challenge abusive governmental systems and offer a way of mercy and compassion, making her relationship with the Divine one of agreement. Our introit and meditation anthems today sing of her strength and power.

Hanacpachap Cussicuinin is a Hymn to Mary from Peru sung in Quechuan, the most widely spoken Indigenous language of the Americas, primarily spoken in the Andes region of South America. This chorale is considered the first piece of recorded choral homophony in the Americas. In meditation, we sing Rachmaninoff's *Bogoroditse Devo* from his Vespers, offering another homophonic prayer to *Mary, full of grace*. The piece premiered in 1915, two years before the rise of the Soviet Union, which led to Rachmaninoff's exile, and the prohibition of any music with religious text sung in public until the death of Stalin in 1953. In those four decades, the *Bogoroditse Devo* became a hymn of Resistance in the region and an emblem of religious liberation: the hymn-like choral writing signifying interconnectedness and strength in community.

In Offertory, we sing *Ihr habt nun Traurigkeit* (*Ye now have sorrow*) from *Ein Deutsches Requiem*, composed by Johannes Brahms soon after the passing of his mother. This fifth movement was written specifically for her: the call and response between soprano soloist and choir illustrating the Divine Feminine comfort of God given freely for all. And finally, we respond in choral benediction with Mary McDonald's spectacular setting of Miller and Jackson's *Let There Be Peace on Earth*, a prayer in the heart of Mary when making her pact with the Holy, and a prayer for our times now." -Dr. Ianthe Marini